Kousa Dogwood

Cornus kousa

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Passage: 2 **TOTAL 2**



Summer / form
Library candidate



Fall color
Library candidate



Flower
Library candidate

Not available

Leaf close-up
Not available

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Deciduous
Mature size: 15–25 ft (sources range 15–20 ft to 20–30 ft). **Open:** Mature height range varies; no tight three-source agreement. × 15–30 ft. Confirmed range.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Suitable for Zone 8a. Hardy Zones 5–8. Not native. More drought-resistant and disease-resistant (including anthracnose) than Cornus florida. Performs well in Atlanta with good drainage. Part shade beneficial in extreme heat. Restart pass (2026-10-13): NC State confirms disease resistance relative to native dogwood. Existing notes stand.
Sun: Full sun to part shade.
Water: Medium. Prefers moist, well-drained soil. More drought tolerant than C. florida once established.
Soil: Well-drained, acidic preferred. Adaptable.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun to part shade in well-drained soil. Part shade beneficial in hot Atlanta summers. Water regularly until established. Minimal pruning. Good alternative to C. florida for disease resistance.
Soil prep: Well-drained, acidic preferred. Adaptable.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to East Asia (Japan, China, Korea). Introduced for ornamental use. More resistant to anthracnose than flowering dogwood.
Form / habit: Deciduous. Small tree. Vase-shaped in youth, becoming horizontal and layered with age. Moderate growth.
Foliage: Scarlet to purple-red.
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Exfoliating gray, tan, and brown (camouflage pattern with age).
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: More resistant to anthracnose and drought than Cornus florida. Still potentially susceptible to other dogwood issues when stressed. Generally lower disease pressure. **Open:** Specific Zone 8a incidence is thin.
Not stated
Additional:
- Creamy-white pointed bracts in late spring (after foliage). - Pink-red spherical fruit (edible but mealy). - Exfoliating bark. - Horizontal branching with age. - Better disease resistance than C. florida.